

Melodic Transcendence in a Dichotomy:
Schubert's Exploration of Life and Death

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Many believe that certain pieces of music become lifelong companions. For me, no piece embodies this more than Franz Schubert's Third Impromptu from Op. 90. I have played it enough times that its melody feels almost instinctive: a quiet, singing line floating above a constant stream of broken chords. For years, I heard the piece simply as peaceful. But the more I learned about Schubert and began looking beneath its surface, the more complicated that peace became. What I once heard as a serene stream began to sound like something more human: moments of innocence, fear, pain, acceptance, and solitude unfolding within the same piece.

Schubert was diagnosed with syphilis in the summer of 1822 and subsequently fell into a deep depression, describing himself as "the most unhappy and wretched creature in the world" (Schubert, 1826). His symptoms later eased, and in 1827, one year before his death, he composed eight impromptus, including the four eventually published as Op. 90. Around the same time, he was writing *Winterreise*, a song cycle filled with images of isolation, loss, and death. I cannot know whether Schubert intended the Third Impromptu to reflect his illness or mortality, and I do not want to impose a meaning onto the piece that he never intended. Still, knowing his circumstances has made it impossible for me to hear the music in quite the same way.

That realization began with something I had never paid much attention to: the broken chords beneath the melody. They are present almost continuously, flowing underneath the melody like water. I had always imagined the opening as a peaceful stream, so I was surprised to hear renowned pianist András Schiff use almost exactly the same image in a 2016 masterclass. Schiff encouraged a student to play the chords like the calm flow of water in a babbling brook. His description stayed with me because it gave words to something I had instinctively felt while playing.

But after studying the piece more closely, I began to wonder whether the stream was really as peaceful as I had thought.

Schubert wrote during the transition between the Classical and Romantic periods, and the Third Impromptu carries qualities of both. Its ternary structure and recurring themes reflect the Classical tradition, while its lyricism, rich harmonies, and emotional ambiguity feel distinctly Romantic. I became particularly interested in the way Schubert repeats musical ideas. The melody returns again and again, but rarely exactly as before. He changes the harmony and decorates familiar ideas with additional non-chord tones, making something recognizable feel subtly different each time. To me, this began to resemble memory: returning to something familiar while never experiencing it in exactly the same way.

The melody in mm. 9–16 is where I hear this most clearly. Its simplicity makes it feel almost intimate. Beneath it, the opening harmonic progression—tonic, submediant, supertonic, and authentic cadence—provides a gentle foundation. At first, there is little reason to feel uneasy. The music seems content simply to exist. That was how I originally understood the piece: beautiful, but uncomplicated. Then, I examined the key of the piece.

Schubert chose G-flat major, a notoriously difficult key for both composers and pianists. His publishers apparently considered the choice so impractical that they originally published the Impromptu in G major instead, believing G-flat major would be too difficult for pianists to play. Yet today, G-flat major is inseparable from the identity of the piece. I find that irony fitting. What initially seems unnecessarily difficult becomes part of what makes the piece distinctive.

More importantly, Schubert spends much of the opening A section firmly within G-flat major. The limited harmonic movement contributes to the feeling of stability I had always

associated with the opening. Knowing Schubert's fluctuating health, I began to hear this stability differently. I imagined a moment in which life could still feel normal—a period of relative calm in which perhaps the future did not seem quite so threatening. I cannot know whether Schubert heard it that way, but that possibility changed the way I played the opening. I became less interested in making it merely “beautiful” and more interested in preserving its innocence.

The B section disrupts that innocence. In m. 25, Schubert moves from G-flat major to its relative minor, E-flat minor. The modulation itself is not particularly surprising for a piece in ternary form, but its effect on the character of the music is. From E-flat minor, he moves into C-flat major in m. 31. The melody becomes quieter while the harmonies become more elaborate, and suddenly the music feels almost eerie. When Schubert returns to E-flat minor in m. 40, the darkness recedes almost as quickly as it appeared.

I find this fleeting quality important. The music does not become consumed by despair. Instead, it seems to acknowledge something painful and then move past it. That made me reconsider what I had previously thought of as the piece's “peacefulness.” Perhaps peace does not mean the absence of pain. Perhaps it can mean experiencing pain without allowing it to consume you.

The return of the A section makes this even more striking. The first sixteen measures of the final A section, mm. 55–70, are essentially identical to the opening. Yet after hearing the B section, I cannot hear them in the same way. The melody has not changed, but I have. What initially sounded like uncomplicated serenity now feels more reflective, almost as though the music remembers everything that came before it. Even the coda carries traces of the earlier C-flat major harmonies, allowing the uneasiness of the B section to linger beneath the familiar surface.

And then, just when the piece seems ready to end peacefully, Schubert surprises me. In mm. 79–81, he suddenly moves to G minor. The modulation lasts only three measures, but it feels startling because G minor is so distant from the harmonic world he has established. It is almost as though the music briefly resists the ending it seemed destined for. I hear this moment as one last attempt to change course—to escape the calm that has gradually returned. But the attempt lasts only three measures. Schubert returns to the serene material of the opening, and the piece ends as quietly as it began.

This is the moment that has changed my interpretation of the entire piece. I no longer hear the ending as simply peaceful. I hear it as acceptance. The music does not defeat its darker moments or pretend they never happened. It passes through them and eventually returns to the same melody, but with a different understanding of it.

That interpretation has also changed how I want to play the Impromptu. I want the opening to feel innocent rather than merely soft; the B section to feel unsettled rather than simply louder; and the final return to feel reflective rather than repetitive. I especially want to bring attention to the C-flat major passage between mm. 31–40 and the unexpected G-minor modulation in mm. 79–81. These moments can easily disappear beneath the flowing eighth notes, but to me, they are where the piece becomes most human.

Arguably, some of the world's greatest pianists have recorded the Impromptu, including Vladimir Horowitz, Daniel Barenboim, Krystian Zimerman, and Murray Perahia. Each plays the same notes differently. I used to think that meant there was a correct interpretation I had yet to discover. Now I think that is part of what makes the piece a lifelong companion. The notes do not

change, but I do. The piece that sounded simply peaceful to me years ago can now sound nostalgic, uncertain, or even mournful depending on what I bring to it.

Perhaps that is why I keep returning to Schubert's Third Impromptu. Like a lifelong companion, it has remained the same while my understanding of it has changed. I began by hearing a peaceful stream. I now hear something moving beneath the water: a person confronting uncertainty, briefly losing his way, and ultimately returning to stillness. Whether or not that was what Schubert intended, it is what the piece has come to mean to me.

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